on face value without factoring in the aforementioned considerations would lead to unreliable inferences—a rookie mistake most media sources were making when discussing India's death rate during the pandemic years. On similar lines, the problem with using the SRS is that it is only an estimate of deaths and not recorded deaths, making it less accurate for use in data collection, analysis and research.[6] For instance, if surveys were done in more high caseload areas, the generalization to total Indian population would not yield real numbers. Many health experts and data scientists such as Chinmay Tumbe[7], Abhishek Anand et al'[8] from the Center for Global Development, Bhramar Mukherjee[9] and many others came out with papers and opinion pieces analysing how India's death rates were anywhere between four to 10 times higher than official numbers. These studies used mostly SRS and Consumer Pyramids Household Surveys (CPHSs), which collected data from select households in the country and then generalized it to total population, basically working on estimates versus reality. In fact, CPHS mostly collected employment and income data, with mortality data as an add-on. Obviously, there was no way to ascertain if respondents answered to questions rather honestly or not. Oddly, the studies, despite using similar methodologies, contradicted themselves, with many saying that India's death rate was four times higher[10], while others pegging it at 10 times[11]. Such studies came to be quoted by several media organizations, pushing an already worried India population in the throes of sadness.

When the second wave of COVID-19 rampaged through the rural and semi-rural areas of the heartland states, several households didn't register deaths occurring. Driven into poverty after a year of the pandemic, many of them couldn't afford to purchase the wood for the pyre and other materials required for performing cremations. Instead, upholding the Hindu ritual of Jal Samadhi, many chose to immerse the dead in the Ganga or bury them in the sand along the banks of the holy river. Jal Samadhi, since generations, is especially common amongst select communities to cremate unmarried people.[12] In fact, every now and then as bodies float ashore, journalists put up pictures in the media questioning the ritual; for instance, in 2015 when Gargi Rawat of NDTV tweeted, 'Shocker from Unnao in UP. Over 100 dead bodies floating in the #Ganga, many just lying in the shallow water #River'.[13] However, during the time of a pandemic, it drew heavy criticism, so much so that UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath hurriedly announced a